

Commercial security solutions providers also have the burden of convincing you that you have a particular problem and that you need the solution in the first place. Later, they need to sell you the same product all over again, the next season.

Technically, every so-called security solution is just a ragbag of software, which puts up some security controls —whether you need them or not is a different question.

Because you can always access, review and change the code, the benefits of using open source are obvious and proven. Especially, backdoors and design flaws, like in encryption, can be detected much more easily and will often be fixed in a very short time.

Q Do you think it is open source that makes not just Fedora Security Lab but several other penetration testing solutions successful in the current market?

Free and unlimited access, of course, is one prime reason to make penetration testing solutions successful in the market, whereas community-driven documentation and to-dos are the other reason.

I also think that most open source tools exist because the creator just needed these to get real work done without focusing on profit. With the UNIX philosophy in mind, which is, “Write programs that do one thing and do it well,” we have an extensive collection of tools that do exactly that. Bundling the good tools to work well together and out-of-the-box makes the solution a success.

Q You have built an active community around various developments related to open source solutions. Why is there a need for a community to maintain a platform like Fedora Security Lab?

Having a real world use-case is imperative. If you do not have a community of users, you will not be able to develop a community of contributors. For instance, students often choose to write an open source tool for their project work at their university, but these tools are not maintained afterwards because a community is missing.

I am quite certain that without people like Fabian Affolter and many contributors from the Fedora Infrastructure Team, who really care and are working on it busily all the time, the FSL project would not last long.

Q How do you handle community engagements to enhance the features of Fedora Security Lab?

Having a contributor-friendly ecosystem keeps the project running. A lot of contribution for FSL comes from the community of the Fedora Project itself. You will find all the new features that come with the operating system in FSL as well.

We host our related content for FSL on the *fedorahost.org* website. Its technical showcase is built by the Fedora

“You cannot just test in the wild, without penalties.”

build servers, while the Fedora design, marketing, website and ambassador group help to spread the word.

People who want to contribute to FSL directly can do that by joining the Fedora Project in the Fedora Account System. They can then contribute content directly to our FSL group —to the documentation team, as a package maintainer or to another group within Fedora. In any case, we are approachable for mentoring.

Q What are your plans for expanding Fedora's presence in India?

Making FSL a part of the Fedora Project is my plan to expand the entire platform. The nice side-effect is that I can teach about what I know well, which is information security. And I can teach it along with my favourite platform, FSL, and my favourite methodology the Open Source Security Testing Methodology Manual (OSSTMM).

As and when time and budgets allow me, I often travel through my beloved India, giving talks and teaching at universities and conferences regarding FSL. I consider myself a part of the Indian null security community and the Fedora community.

I have travelled to India at least once a year since 2009 to spread the word. I teach for free —if there are charges or certification fees, they go directly to the communities, and enable more research and development.

Q What is the prime target audience for Fedora Security Lab? Also, where does India feature in your audience?

I think FSL is the perfect platform for teaching security testing. This recommendation clearly goes for teachers, students and various security testers who want to use Fedora as their base OS for testing.

If I give a piece of training in Germany, it can happen that I have 30 professors in the training round but not a single student. However, this is not the case in India.

In India, during a talk, it can easily be 200 students, professionals and more. So India is my No. 1 audience.

Q As you have been a mentor for Fedora Project contributors, have you seen some Indians making major contributions towards the open source venture?

The interesting thing with mentoring is that you are a mentor and being mentored at the same time. I could attach a long list of people who I consider valuable for the open source movement. I am sure I would miss someone important. So I only want to mention Atul Chitnis — who passed away much too soon — as one who built and shaped the open source ecosystem on Indian soil significantly.